THE REBOU

India's T20 WC title defence was powered not by a single superstar but by a clutch of inspirational stories—players who turned setbacks into match-winning resolve

By SUHANI SINGH

Kapil had his Devils; Dhoni his squadron of reliable soldiers, and Rohit a team of boisterous boys. But you'd be hard put to call the current iteration of the Men in Blue, who ensured that India became the first nation to successfully defend the ICC T20 World Cup title, SKY's Stars. Falling for that tempting metaphor would emphasise exceptional, singular figures. Instead, Suryakumar Yadav's men were built around that simple code: team work. Coach Gautam Gambhir said as much in his post-title speech, noting that the "team should always supersede individuals". This was a team that wasn't counting on a lodestar or two and, despite being favourites, didn't seem invincible. There were chinks in the armour, but also a many-spangled armoury of powerful weapons, each of which came good in serial fashion. So yes, the team's success also flowed from the herculean effort of individuals who, when pushed to the edge, put their best foot forward and turned adversity into advantage.

For Sanju Samson, it was a fight for survival. After a rollercoaster decade of call-ups, missed opportunities and being ignored, he had his moment of glory—not once, but thrice. Gambhir would admit that India's game-changing moment in the tournament came when Samson scored 97 not out against the West Indies. For Hardik Pandya, it was a mission to prove that he was both mentally and physically determined to cement his position as the bankable all-rounder. Vice-captain Axar Patel rose to the occasion after being dropped against South Africa. Ishan Kishan, after losing his spot in the India squad, sharpened his skills with Jharkand and IPL's Sunrisers until he made a comeback. A more mature Kishan is now ranked No. 2 amongst batsmen in T20s. And then the captain himself. Though Suryakumar did not set the knockouts alight with the bat, he stood out for his calm leadership and sharp decision-making.

Passion and perseverance form the mortar that binds this quintet. And that combination goes a long way. ■



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SANJU SAMSON
MATCHES: 5
RUNS: 321
HS: 97*
S/R: 199.37